

FIRST CONGREGATIONAL CHURCH
of Los Angeles

Eastertide 1

Resisting with Joy ~ Perspective

12 April 2026



*The Dalai Lama and Archbishop Desmond Tutu
Photo by Miranda Penn Turin*

540 S. Commonwealth Avenue, Los Angeles, California 90020
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The Gathering of the People

First Congregational Church of Los Angeles is a safe place for all people, and we celebrate our diversity of race, creed, age, ability, gender, religion, cultural background, sexual orientation, gender identities and expressions... We extend a warm welcome to all this morning and especially those who are with us for the first time. Your presence both enriches us and this time of celebration together ~

Please note that our services are live streamed at fccla.org/live.

Organ Prelude Concert

Dr. Christoph Bull, Organist-in-Residence

Improvisation on SLANE and LANCASHIRE

DUKE STREET (Kenneth T. Kosche)

Bicinium on LLANFAIR (John Barr)

Improvisation on *O FILII ET FILIAE*

Meditation on NOËL NOUVELET /
Now The Green Blade Rises (Christoph Bull)

Meditation on *Victimae Paschali Laudes*
Vic 1 (Christoph Bull)

Chiming of the Hour

Welcome

Rev. Laura Vail Fregin

Words of Gathering

Rev. Fregin & Meg Russett

As we gather together,
may today offer us what our spirits need
to evolve, to expand, to unfold.

May this day stretch us just enough,
not by force or demand,
but through the kind of invitation that only opens slowly,
too careful to be rushed.

May we be brave enough to loosen our grip
on what we know and perceive –
on what we have learned from fear
or inherited from lineages of cruelty.

May we give thanks for all the sources that gifted us with
survival and wisdom, perspective and protection,
without letting our gratitude unnecessarily wed us to them forever.

In this time together, may we sense the import of this moment.
May we know it deep within our souls
as we open our hands and hearts,
to the beauty and joy of this life we share.

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!

Please stand in body or in spirit for our Hymn of Gathering

***Hymn of Gathering**

The Journey

LANCASHIRE

Dawn heralds this day's journey; light floods the earth with gold;
We feast on morning's freshness as peace our world enfolds.
Earth offers us her beauty; bright blue the sky and sea;
We pause in silent wonder, at one with all we see.

Trees reach into the sunlight; bright dewdrops on their leaves;
We wait in joy or sorrow as life her pattern weaves.
Wind dances in the valleys, flight takes the birds to air;
We hold these fleeting moments as signs of sacred care.

Clouds move across the heavens; light breaks within the storm;
We bless the rain of springtime as night again is born.
Dusk calls the world to slumber; night draws the Milky Way;
We rest in sacred spaces, as darkness ends the day.

Creation in completeness, vitality and grace;
Gives warmth and hope and meaning to all the human race.
Life shares with us her treasures; our hearts and minds aware;
We give our thanks for living, as joyful life we share.

-lyrics by Helen Wiltshire

Prayer of Awareness

Rev. Fregin

Holy One,
In this Eastertide, we open ourselves to the possibilities of joy.
When the world so often inspires sadness and grief,
help us, Creator of Light, to sense and know true joy still.

When the world is overwhelmed by the shadows,
help us to seize joy's delights.

When the world is caught up in sensationalism,
help us speak of the hidden wonders we've discovered,
holding them up for others to see.

*And then, Holy One, surprise us with your nearness, O Sacred Presence,
that we would hear our true name whispered again: beloved;
that that naming would be our joy.*

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us.
Amen and Amen.

***Introit**

"Rejoice, Ye Grateful Hearts"
Cathedral Choir

***The Lord's Prayer**

Meg Russett

*Holy One, beyond all names,
Eternal Wellspring,
May love rise again in us today
with food for every table,
shelter for every family,
and reverence for every life.
Forgive us our failings in love
and free us from all falseness,
that the light of our souls may shine,
and the strength of our spirits endure
for Earth and all its people
This day, tonight, and forever.*

John Philip Newell

Amen and Amen!

***Gloria Deo**

Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.
World without end, Amen, Amen.

***Passing of the Peace**

Rev. Fregin

It is in the depths of life that we find you—
at the heart of this moment,
at the center of our souls,
deep in the earth and its eternal stirrings.

You are the Ground of all being,
the Well-Spring of time,
Womb of the earth,
the Seed-Force of stars.

And so at the opening of this day
we wait,
not for blessings from afar
but for You
the very Soil of our souls
the early Freshness of morning
the first Breath of day.

[Iona]

On this day, may the joy and peace of God be with you.
And also with you!

You are invited to share this ancient greeting with a bow

Please be seated

from the Gospel of John, Chapter 20

Mary of Magdala stood weeping beside the tomb, even as she wept, she stooped to peer inside, and there she saw two angels in dazzling robes. One was seated at the head and the other at the foot of the place where Jesus' body had lain.

They asked Mary, 'Why are you weeping?' Mary answered them, 'Because they have taken away my Rabbi, and I do not know where they have put the body.'

No sooner had she said this than she turned around and caught sight of Jesus standing there, but she didn't know it was Jesus. Jesus asked her, 'Why are you weeping? For whom are you looking?' Mary supposed it was the gardener and said, 'Please, if you are the one who carried Jesus away, tell me where you've laid the body and I will take it away.'

Jesus said to her, 'Mary!' She turned to Jesus and said, 'Rabboni!' - which means Teacher. Jesus then said, 'Don't hold on to me, for I have not yet ascended to Abba God. Rather, go to my friends and tell them, 'I'm ascending to my Abba and to your Abba, my God and your God!'

Mary of Magdala went to the disciples. 'I have seen the Teacher!' she announced.

Then she reported what Jesus had said to her.

This is the Gospel of Grace.
Thanks be to God!

Prayers with the People

Rev. Fregin

Invitation to Silence and Prayer

We invite you in this time to write the prayers of your hearts for your life, our shared life, and the life of the world. And then, as the music begins, to come forward and offer your prayers here in this bowl, and to light candles, signifying the prayers of all our hearts.

Silence

Prayer of Our Hearts

Most Holy One,
you are the Order within Chaos,
the Chaos within Order,
the Life within Death,
the Death within Life.

You are, O God, the air we breathe,
the sound of silence,
the laughter of children,
the weeping of the forlorn,
the longing for peace,
the dream of justice,
the tear of joy.

You are the Presence and Power within us,
Being and Life of all,
and in this sacred place,
how we are filled,
how we overflow
with love and goodness.

Help us, in these moments,
to fling open our hearts
to the beauty and joy of it all.

*We pray this as those who are grateful
for the ever rising Christ within our lives.
Amen and Amen.*

Meditation Anthem

“Draw Us In The Spirit’s Tether”
Laude

arr. SAUNDER CHOI

Sermon

Perspective ~ Seeing Life from All Angles

Rev. Michael Lehman

Invitation to Generosity

Meg Russett

At First Church, we consider every pledge, tithe, offering and contribution a gift for the life of our community of faith. No matter how they’re given, our gifts show gratitude. You are invited to visit our website at fccla.org/give. Our hospitality team will also bring baskets for your in-person gifts during the Offertory.

Offertory

“The Heavens Are Telling” from *The Creation*
Cathedral Choir, Scott Graff, Fahad Siadat, Laurel Irene, Soloists

FRANZ JOSEPH HAYDN

***Doxology**

From all that dwell below the skies,
let the Creator’s praise arise!
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Your name shall sound and praises soar
till suns shall rise and set no more.
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Alleluia! Alleluia! Alleluia!

[adapt/Isaac Watts, 1719]

***Offering Prayer**

Meg Russett

Holy One of Many Names,
may these gifts be used
to bring comfort and courage,
hope and love
to all your children.

And may we work, O God,
to end the violence and suffering
that plague your many children
around the world.

*On this day, may our work for peace
be sustained by joy,
that our resistance to the ways of death and despair
be not only on our lips,
but expressed through our lives and in our actions.
Amen and Amen.*

Please be seated

Life at First Church

Rev. Fregin & Rev. Lehman

Words of Blessing

Rev. Lehman

On this day, Holy One, with thankful hearts,
we ask that you set free our souls and unbind our love,
that we may sense and share the joy all around us.

*For all that has been, O God, we give you thanks.
For all that is now, O God, we give our love and care.
For all that will be, O God, we open ourselves
to what we can create together -
with you, and with each other.*

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!

Choral Response

"It Takes A Whole Village"
Cathedral Choir, Molly Pease, *Soloist*

JOAN SZYMKO

***Hymn for the Journey**

Come Now, O Wisdom

SLANE

Come now, O Wisdom, we need your clear voice;
Speak and awaken our hearts to rejoice.
Gracious Creator of more than we know,
In your own image may we ever grow.

Come now, O Wisdom, abide in our souls;
Stir in us visions of life free and whole.
Wisdom, our pathway to justice and peace,
With you our dreams find their fullest release.

Wisdom, more precious than rubies or gold,
With you our graces forever unfold.
No fame or fortune with you can compare;
Pour out your blessings, so rich and so rare.

Wisdom your grace joins all heaven and earth;
With you we labor new life to give birth.
Come now, O Wisdom, our Midwife and Friend,
Open our hearts to your world without end.

-Lyrics by Jann Aldredge-Clanton

Postlude

Dr. Christoph Bull, *Organist-in-Residence*
Vic 1 - Reprise (Christoph Bull)

Inside The Music

Dr. David Harris

"I'm elated to be exploring "The Book Of Joy" during Eastertide. It flows from one of the more interesting connections in history at a time when we seek new connections. The music this week focuses on expansive musical expressions. Saunder's setting of "Draw Us In The Spirit's Tether" blends easy joy with a folk-like confidence. The text comes from a hymn with different music and speaks of the beauty of gathering together with diverse people in a common spirit. This is precisely what occurred with Bishop Tutu and the Dalai Lama. I chose Haydn's "Heavens Are Telling" from "The Creation" because of its hopeful energy. With the world created and fresh, this movement expresses gratitude for all that may come to be. The joy and gratitude are shared by all beings across the earth and in the heavens. Haydn doesn't insinuate that everyone has the same experience or perspective, but simply that everyone shares in collective expressions of joy. In diverse communities, we can never hope to understand people's perspectives fully. We all have lives full of radically different stories. We can, however, hope to open ourselves to hearing one another in each moment we have together. We also have the promise that we can share in mutual experiences made more rich by our diversity. That's a promise worth learning to hear one another for. Finally, we are reminded that we need every one of us to bring about the richness of each individual in Symko's "It Takes A Whole Village." Although the well-known proverb speaks of raising children, we can easily appreciate each tender moment we have together as a child of the moment, and each of us as children ever growing into ourselves."